

Office Automation and Secretarial Practices - BBA Sem 3 Notes

BBA Semester 3 — Course Code VOC169 — Detailed Notes

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Unit I: Office Organization, Modern Office Concepts & Filing

(BBA Sem 3 — VOC169 — 8 Lectures)

1. Meaning and Importance of Office

Meaning

An Office can be defined as a **place where clerical, administrative, and managerial activities are carried out to plan, coordinate, and control the various operations of a business organization**. It is the center where information is received, recorded, processed, and communicated to support decision-making across the organization.

In a broader sense, an office is not just a physical location but also refers to the **function of handling information and paperwork** necessary for the smooth functioning of a business — regardless of whether that function is carried out in a traditional physical space or a virtual/digital environment (a distinction explored later in this unit).

Importance of Office

- **Information hub** — The office serves as the central point where data and information from various departments are collected, processed, and disseminated to support management decisions.
- **Coordination center** — It facilitates coordination between different departments and functions of a business (production, sales, finance, HR), ensuring smooth overall operations.
- **Record-keeping** — The office maintains essential business records (financial, legal, employee-related) that are necessary for compliance, decision-making, and historical reference.
- **Communication facilitator** — The office manages internal and external communication, ensuring timely and accurate flow of information to stakeholders.
- **Supports decision-making** — By organizing and presenting information systematically, the office enables management to make informed, timely decisions.
- **Public relations and image building** — The office is often the first point of contact for clients, visitors, and stakeholders, and

therefore plays a role in shaping the organization's public image.

2. Functions of an Office

The functions of an office can be broadly categorized into two types:

A. Basic (Primary) Functions

- **Receiving Information** — Collecting information from various internal and external sources (mail, email, phone calls, reports)
- **Recording Information** — Systematically documenting information in appropriate formats (registers, files, databases) for future reference
- **Processing/Arranging Information** — Organizing, analyzing, and preparing information in a usable format for management (e.g., preparing summary reports from raw data)
- **Supplying/Communicating Information** — Distributing processed information to the relevant departments, management, or external stakeholders who need it

B. Administrative (Management) Functions

- **Planning office work** — Determining what work needs to be done, and how office resources should be allocated
- **Organizing office activities** — Structuring office tasks, staff roles, and workflows for efficiency
- **Staffing** — Recruiting, training, and placing the right personnel in office roles
- **Directing and supervising** — Guiding and overseeing office staff to ensure work is performed correctly and efficiently
- **Controlling** — Monitoring office operations to ensure they align with organizational standards and objectives, and taking corrective action where needed

Exam tip: “Functions of an office” is a common 6-mark question — structure your answer using the Basic Functions (Receiving, Recording, Processing, Supplying information) as the primary/core answer, and mention Administrative Functions as a secondary layer if more depth is needed.

3. Office Organization

Office Organization refers to the **systematic arrangement of office activities, personnel, and resources** to ensure work flows smoothly and objectives are achieved efficiently. It involves defining

roles, responsibilities, reporting relationships, and workflows within the office.

Key aspects of office organization:

- **Division of work** — Breaking down office tasks into specific roles/departments (e.g., correspondence, filing, accounts) so that each person/unit has clear responsibility
 - **Defining authority and responsibility** — Establishing who has decision-making authority and who is accountable for specific outcomes
 - **Establishing communication channels** — Setting clear paths for information flow, both vertically (between management and staff) and horizontally (between departments)
 - **Centralization vs. Decentralization of office services** — Deciding whether common office services (like filing, typing, or reception) are handled by a single central unit or distributed across individual departments (this concept is revisited under filing systems below)
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4. Role of Office Staff, Office Manager & Support Services

Role of Office Staff

Office staff handle the day-to-day clerical and administrative tasks that keep the office functioning — correspondence handling, data entry, filing, reception duties, and coordination between departments. Their efficiency directly affects the smoothness of office operations.

Role of the Office Manager

The Office Manager is responsible for **planning, organizing, staffing, directing, and controlling all office activities**, essentially applying general management functions specifically to the office environment. Key responsibilities include:

- Supervising office staff and ensuring efficient work allocation
- Ensuring adequate office equipment, supplies, and layout are maintained
- Implementing office systems and procedures (filing, record-keeping, communication protocols)
- Handling office budgets and controlling office-related costs
- Ensuring a productive and comfortable working environment for staff

Support Services

Support services refer to the **auxiliary functions that assist the core office operations**, such as:

- Reception and telephone handling
- Mail handling (inward and outward correspondence — a topic developed further in Unit III)
- Reprographics (photocopying, printing, scanning)
- IT/technical support for office equipment and systems
- Housekeeping and general office maintenance

Exam tip: “Role of an office manager” is a frequently tested 6-mark question — structure your answer using the management functions (Planning, Organizing, Staffing, Directing, Controlling) applied specifically to office context.

5. Concept of Modern Office

The traditional office — centered around paper files, physical presence, and manual processes — has evolved considerably with advances in technology. Several important modern office concepts are relevant here:

A. Paperless Office

A Paperless Office refers to an office environment where **most or all documentation, communication, and record-keeping is conducted digitally rather than on physical paper**. This is enabled by technologies such as email, cloud storage, digital document management systems, and e-signatures.

Benefits: Reduced storage space requirements, faster document retrieval, lower printing/paper costs, easier backup and disaster recovery, and improved environmental sustainability (linking to the environmental sustainability concepts from your Business Environment subject).

B. Virtual Environment/Virtual Office

A Virtual Office refers to a work arrangement where **employees perform office functions remotely, without being physically present at a fixed office location**, using digital communication and collaboration tools (video conferencing, cloud-based project management, instant messaging).

Benefits: Reduced overhead costs (rent, utilities), greater flexibility for employees, access to a wider talent pool not restricted by geography, and business continuity even during disruptions (e.g., as

seen during large-scale remote work adoption in recent years).

C. Front Office and Back Office

ASPECT	FRONT OFFICE	BACK OFFICE
Meaning	The part of the office that directly interacts with customers/clients/visitors	The part of the office that handles internal, behind-the-scenes support functions
Visibility	Client-facing, visible to external parties	Not visible to customers; internal operations
Examples	Reception, customer service, sales counter	Accounting, IT support, record-keeping, HR processing
Primary focus	Building relationships and managing external interactions	Ensuring smooth internal processing and operational support

Exam tip: “Front office vs. back office” is a common 2-mark comparison question — the key distinguishing point is client-facing (front) vs. internal support (back).

6. Office Layout, Equipment & Machines

Basics of Office Layout

Office layout refers to the **physical arrangement of furniture, equipment, and workspaces within an office**, designed to promote efficiency, communication, and employee comfort. Good office layout considers:

- Adequate space for movement and workflow between departments/desks
- Proper lighting, ventilation, and ergonomic considerations
- Logical placement of interdependent departments close to each other, to minimize unnecessary movement
- Appropriate placement of shared equipment (printers, filing cabinets) for easy access by relevant staff

Workplace Ethics

Workplace ethics refers to the **moral principles and standards of professional conduct expected of employees within the office environment** — punctuality, honesty, respect for colleagues,

confidentiality of sensitive information, and adherence to organizational policies. (This connects conceptually to the broader business ethics principles covered in your Business Environment, Ethics & Governance subject.)

Use of Office Machines and Equipment

Modern offices rely on a range of machines and equipment to improve efficiency:

- **Computers and printers** — For document creation, processing, and printing
- **Photocopiers/scanners** — For duplicating and digitizing documents
- **Communication equipment** — Telephones, video conferencing systems, intercoms
- **Filing and storage equipment** — Filing cabinets, shelving systems (physical) and servers/cloud storage (digital)
- **Other office equipment** — Fax machines (still used in some contexts), franking machines, shredders for secure document disposal

Exam tip: “Explain the concept of a modern office” is a strong 6-mark question — cover paperless office, virtual office, and front/back office as the three key contemporary concepts, since these represent the biggest shifts from traditional office practice.

7. Filing and Indexing

Meaning of Filing

Filing refers to the **systematic arrangement and storage of documents and records in a manner that allows for their easy and quick retrieval** when needed. It is one of the most fundamental office functions, since businesses generate and must retain large volumes of documents (contracts, correspondence, financial records, employee records).

Objectives and Importance of Filing

- **Easy and quick retrieval of documents** — A good filing system ensures any required document can be located promptly when needed
- **Safe custody of records** — Filing protects important documents from loss, damage, or unauthorized access
- **Legal compliance** — Many documents must be retained for specific periods to comply with legal/regulatory requirements

- **Historical reference** — Filed records serve as a reference for past transactions, decisions, and correspondence
- **Supports decision-making** — Easy access to historical records and data supports better-informed management decisions

Essentials of a Good Filing System

- **Simplicity** — The system should be easy to understand and operate, even by new staff
- **Accessibility** — Documents should be easily retrievable without significant time or effort
- **Flexibility** — The system should be able to accommodate growth in volume and changes in document types over time
- **Economy** — The system should be cost-effective in terms of space, equipment, and staff time required
- **Safety and confidentiality** — Sensitive documents should be protected from unauthorized access, damage, or loss
- **Compactness** — The system should make efficient use of available storage space

Centralized vs. Decentralized Filing

BASIS	CENTRALIZED FILING	DECENTRALIZED FILING
Meaning	All documents are filed and maintained in a single central location/department	Each department maintains its own separate filing system
Control	Uniform control and standardized procedures	Control is spread across departments, less standardization
Advantages	Avoids duplication, easier supervision, efficient use of space and equipment	Faster access for the specific department, greater departmental control
Disadvantages	May cause delay for departments needing frequent access to files	Risk of duplication, inconsistent filing standards across departments

Exam tip: “Centralized vs decentralized filing” is a very commonly tested 2-mark/6-mark comparison — make sure you can state at least one clear advantage and disadvantage of each system.

Practical Filing Methods

- **Alphabetical Filing** — Documents are filed in alphabetical order based on names (of individuals, companies, or subjects) — simple

and widely used, but can become cumbersome with very large volumes or similar names

- **Numerical Filing** — Documents are assigned and filed by number, often supported by a separate alphabetical index to locate the corresponding number — useful for very large systems requiring precise, unambiguous referencing
- **Geographical Filing** — Documents are filed based on geographic location (region, state, city) — useful for organizations with operations spread across different locations
- **Subject Filing** — Documents are filed based on subject matter or topic, regardless of correspondent name — useful when retrieval is more likely to be subject-based than name-based
- **Chronological Filing** — Documents are filed based on date order — often used as a secondary method within another primary filing system (e.g., within an alphabetical file, documents may be arranged chronologically)

Indexing

Indexing refers to the **process of creating a reference guide/list that shows where specific documents or files are located within the filing system**, enabling faster retrieval without needing to search through the entire filing system manually.

Common indexing methods:

- **Card Index** — A physical card system listing file names/subjects along with their location reference
- **Visible Card Index** — Cards arranged in a way that key information is visible without removing individual cards
- **Book/Register Index** — A bound register listing files in some logical order (alphabetical/numerical) with page or location references
- **Computerized/Digital Index** — Modern offices increasingly use searchable digital databases that instantly locate both physical file locations and digital documents

Exam tip: “Explain the methods of filing” is a very high-probability 6-mark question — list and briefly explain all five methods (Alphabetical, Numerical, Geographical, Subject, Chronological) with one line on when each is most useful.

Quick Revision Summary

TOPIC	ONE-LINE TAKEAWAY
Office meaning	Place/function for handling

	information to support business operations
Office importance	Information hub, coordination center, record-keeping, communication, decision support
Basic functions	Receiving, recording, processing, supplying information
Administrative functions	Planning, organizing, staffing, directing, controlling office work
Office Manager role	Applies management functions specifically to office operations
Paperless office	Digital documentation replacing physical paper records
Virtual office	Remote work arrangement using digital communication/collaboration tools
Front office vs Back office	Front = client-facing; Back = internal support functions
Office layout	Physical arrangement of furniture/equipment for efficiency and comfort
Filing meaning	Systematic storage of documents for easy retrieval
Essentials of good filing	Simplicity, accessibility, flexibility, economy, safety, compactness
Centralized vs Decentralized filing	Centralized = single unit, uniform control; Decentralized = departmental, faster local access
Filing methods	Alphabetical, Numerical, Geographical, Subject, Chronological
Indexing	Reference guide to quickly locate filed documents

Unit II: Office Forms and Record Management

(BBA Sem 3 — VOC169 — 7 Lectures)

Part A: Office Forms

1. Meaning and Importance of Office Forms

Meaning

An Office Form is a **standardized document with a fixed format containing blank spaces, designed to collect, record, or communicate specific information in a structured, consistent manner**. Forms are used extensively in business organizations to standardize the way information is captured across repetitive transactions or processes (e.g., a leave application form, a purchase requisition form, a customer complaint form).

Importance of Office Forms

- **Standardization** — Ensures that the same type of information is captured consistently every time a particular transaction/process occurs, regardless of who fills it out
 - **Time-saving** — Pre-printed/pre-designed forms save time compared to drafting a fresh document for each instance of a repetitive transaction
 - **Completeness of information** — A well-designed form prompts the user to provide all necessary information, reducing the chance of missing important details
 - **Easy processing and analysis** — Standardized forms make it easier to process, compare, and analyze data across multiple instances (e.g., comparing expense claims across employees)
 - **Supports record-keeping** — Completed forms often become part of the organization's permanent records, feeding into the Record Management systems discussed later in this unit
 - **Facilitates communication** — Forms provide a clear, structured channel for communicating specific types of information between departments or with external parties
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2. Types of Forms Used in Business Organizations

Forms can be classified in several ways based on their use and origin:

- **Internal Forms** — Used exclusively within the organization for internal communication and processes (e.g., leave application form, internal memo form, requisition form)
- **External Forms** — Used for communication with parties outside the organization (e.g., order forms, invoices, customer feedback forms)
- **Action Forms** — Forms that initiate or request a specific action (e.g., purchase requisition, leave application)
- **Information/Record Forms** — Forms designed primarily to record information for reference purposes (e.g., employee master data form, asset register form)

Common examples of office forms:

- Employee attendance/leave forms
 - Purchase requisition and purchase order forms
 - Invoice and receipt forms
 - Expense claim/reimbursement forms
 - Customer complaint/feedback forms
 - Job application forms
 - Inventory/stock record forms
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3. Objectives of Forms

- To **standardize** the collection and recording of routine business information
 - To ensure **completeness and accuracy** of information collected
 - To **simplify and speed up** routine administrative processes
 - To provide a **permanent record** of transactions and communications for future reference
 - To facilitate **easy comparison and analysis** of data collected across similar transactions
 - To support **compliance** with legal, regulatory, or internal policy documentation requirements
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4. Principles of Forms Design

Good forms design is essential to ensure the form serves its purpose efficiently. Key principles include:

- **Clarity and Simplicity** — The form should use clear, simple language and be easy for the user to understand and complete without confusion
- **Logical Sequence** — Information fields should be arranged in a logical order that matches how the user naturally thinks through or provides the information
- **Adequate Space** — Sufficient space should be provided for each response, particularly for fields likely to require longer answers
- **Appropriate Size and Format** — The form should be an appropriate size for its intended use (e.g., ease of filing, mailing, or digital use) and should use standard formatting where possible
- **Minimal Data Duplication** — The form should avoid asking for the same information more than once
- **Instructions Where Needed** — Forms should include brief, clear instructions for fields that might be ambiguous
- **Provision for Authorization** — Where necessary, forms should include space for signatures, approvals, or authorizations
- **Cost-Effectiveness** — The design should balance functional requirements with the cost of printing/producing the form (especially for high-volume forms)

Exam tip: “Principles of forms design” is a common 6-mark question — list at least 5-6 principles from the above, since examiners typically expect a fairly comprehensive list for this type of question.

5. Control of Forms

Forms Control refers to the **systematic management of an organization’s forms — from design and creation through usage, revision, and eventual discontinuation** — to prevent unnecessary duplication, ensure consistency, and control costs.

Key aspects of forms control:

- **Forms Review/Approval Process** — New forms should go through a review and approval process before being introduced, to ensure they are genuinely necessary and well-designed
- **Avoiding Duplication** — Regularly reviewing existing forms to identify and eliminate overlapping or redundant forms
- **Standardizing Form Numbers/Codes** — Assigning unique identification codes to forms for easy tracking and reference
- **Periodic Review and Revision** — Forms should be periodically reviewed to ensure they remain relevant and effective, and

revised or discontinued as business needs change

- **Centralized Forms Management** — Many organizations designate a specific person/department responsible for overseeing all forms across the organization, to maintain consistency and control costs

Why forms control matters: Without proper control, organizations can accumulate large numbers of outdated, redundant, or poorly designed forms over time, leading to inefficiency, confusion, and unnecessary printing/storage costs.

6. Preparation of Common Office Forms

When preparing standard office forms, the general process typically includes:

1. **Identifying the purpose** — Clearly defining what information the form needs to capture and why
2. **Identifying the target users** — Understanding who will complete the form, to ensure appropriate language and format
3. **Drafting the form layout** — Applying the principles of forms design (discussed above) to create a draft
4. **Review and testing** — Testing the form with actual or representative users to identify any confusion or gaps
5. **Approval and standardization** — Getting the form formally approved and assigning it a standard code/number as per the organization's forms control system
6. **Implementation and periodic review** — Rolling out the form for use, with periodic review to ensure it remains effective over time

Exam tip: A 2-mark question might simply ask “What is a forms control system?” or “Define office forms” — keep these crisp, while being ready to expand into the full principles/control process for a 6-mark question.

Part B: Record Management

7. Meaning, Need and Importance of Record Keeping

Meaning

Record Management (also called Records Management) refers to the **systematic control of an organization's records throughout their lifecycle** — from creation and receipt, through maintenance and use, to eventual disposal or permanent preservation. It is a broader, more strategic concept than simple filing (covered in Unit I), encompassing the full lifecycle management of business records.

Need and Importance of Record Keeping

- **Legal Compliance** — Many types of business records (financial statements, tax records, employment records) must be legally retained for specified periods
 - **Evidence in Disputes** — Well-maintained records serve as crucial evidence in legal disputes, audits, or regulatory investigations
 - **Decision-making Support** — Historical records provide valuable data and context for management decision-making
 - **Operational Continuity** — Proper records ensure business operations can continue smoothly even if key personnel change, since institutional knowledge is preserved in documented form
 - **Accountability and Transparency** — Good record-keeping supports organizational accountability and transparency toward stakeholders (linking to the transparency principle from your Business Environment, Ethics & Governance subject)
 - **Historical Reference** — Records provide a valuable historical record of the organization's activities, useful for reference, research, or institutional memory
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8. Methods of Maintaining Records

- **Manual/Physical Record-Keeping** — Traditional method using physical files, registers, and ledgers, stored in filing cabinets or record rooms
- **Mechanized Record-Keeping** — Using basic office machines (typewriters historically, or simple mechanical aids) to assist in record preparation and maintenance
- **Computerized/Digital Record-Keeping** — Using computer systems, databases, and software applications to create, store, and manage records digitally — increasingly the dominant method in modern offices
- **Cloud-Based Record-Keeping** — Storing records on remote servers accessible via the internet, allowing for easier backup, remote access, and collaboration (an extension of digital record systems, discussed further below)

9. Classification and Preservation of Records

Classification of Records

Records can be classified based on various criteria:

- **Based on Importance/Value:**
 - **Vital Records** — Records essential for the continued functioning of the organization, which would be irreplaceable if lost (e.g., legal titles, incorporation documents)
 - **Important Records** — Records that are valuable and would be costly/difficult to replace, but not absolutely essential for survival (e.g., detailed financial records, contracts)
 - **Useful Records** — Records that have short-term operational value but are not critical long-term (e.g., routine correspondence)
 - **Non-essential Records** — Records with minimal ongoing value that can typically be discarded after a short retention period (e.g., routine notices, superseded drafts)
- **Based on Physical Form:** Paper records, digital/electronic records, microfilm records, audio-visual records
- **Based on Function:** Financial records, personnel/HR records, legal records, correspondence records, operational/production records

Preservation of Records

Preservation refers to the **measures taken to protect records from damage, deterioration, loss, or unauthorized access** over their required retention period. Key preservation considerations:

- **Physical protection** — Appropriate storage conditions (temperature, humidity, fire/water protection) for physical records
- **Digital preservation** — Regular backups, secure servers, and protection against data corruption or cyber threats for digital records
- **Access control** — Restricting access to sensitive/confidential records to authorized personnel only
- **Retention scheduling** — Establishing clear policies on how long different types of records must be retained, based on legal requirements and business needs, before they can be safely destroyed

Exam tip: “Classification of records based on importance” (Vital, Important, Useful, Non-essential) is a frequently tested 6-mark question — make sure you can define each category with one

example.

10. Centralization and Decentralization of Record Keeping

This mirrors the centralized vs. decentralized filing concept from Unit I, but applied specifically to the broader records management function:

BASIS	CENTRALIZED RECORD KEEPING	DECENTRALIZED RECORD KEEPING
Meaning	All organizational records are maintained in one central records department	Each department/unit maintains its own records independently
Control	Uniform policies, standards, and control across the organization	Control and standards may vary across departments
Advantages	Consistency, easier compliance monitoring, economies of scale in storage/staffing	Faster access for the specific department that generates/uses the records regularly
Disadvantages	Possible delays for departments needing frequent access; central department may become a bottleneck	Risk of inconsistent practices, duplication, and difficulty in organization-wide compliance monitoring

Exam tip: This comparison is very similar in structure to the centralized/decentralized filing comparison from Unit I — examiners sometimes test them as related but distinct questions, so be ready to discuss this at the broader “records management” level, not just physical filing.

11. Use of Digital Record Systems in Offices

Modern offices increasingly rely on **digital record management systems (also called Electronic Document and Records Management Systems — EDRMS)** to manage the full lifecycle of records electronically.

Key features and benefits of digital record systems:

- **Faster search and retrieval** — Digital systems allow instant keyword-based search across large volumes of records, far faster

than manual physical search

- **Space efficiency** — Eliminates the need for extensive physical storage space required for paper records
- **Improved security** — Digital systems can implement access controls, encryption, and audit trails to protect sensitive records
- **Easier backup and disaster recovery** — Digital records can be backed up and recovered far more reliably than physical records vulnerable to fire, flood, or physical damage
- **Version control** — Digital systems can track different versions of a document, showing changes made over time
- **Remote accessibility** — Authorized users can access records remotely, supporting the virtual office concept discussed in Unit I
- **Integration with other systems** — Digital record systems can often integrate with other business software (accounting systems, CRM, HR systems) for seamless data flow

Challenges of digital record systems: Initial setup and migration costs, cybersecurity risks, need for staff training, and dependency on reliable IT infrastructure.

Exam tip: “Advantages of digital/computerized record-keeping systems” is a common 6-mark question — list at least 5-6 benefits from the above, and consider briefly mentioning challenges too for a more balanced, comprehensive answer.

Quick Revision Summary

TOPIC	ONE-LINE TAKEAWAY
Office Forms meaning	Standardized documents for consistent collection/recording of information
Types of forms	Internal, external, action forms, information/record forms
Objectives of forms	Standardization, accuracy, speed, permanent record, easy analysis
Principles of forms design	Clarity, logical sequence, adequate space, minimal duplication, cost-effectiveness
Forms control	Systematic management of forms from creation to discontinuation, avoiding duplication
Record Management meaning	Systematic control of records throughout their entire lifecycle

Need for record keeping	Legal compliance, evidence, decision support, continuity, accountability
Methods of maintaining records	Manual, mechanized, computerized/digital, cloud-based
Record classification (by importance)	Vital, Important, Useful, Non-essential records
Record preservation	Physical/digital protection, access control, retention scheduling
Centralized vs Decentralized records	Centralized = uniform control; Decentralized = faster departmental access
Digital record systems	Faster retrieval, space-saving, better security, remote access, version control

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Unit III: Secretarial Practice and Business Communication

(BBA Sem 3 — VOC169 — 8 Lectures)

Part A: Secretarial Practice

1. Meaning and Importance of a Secretary

Meaning

A Secretary is a **person responsible for handling administrative, clerical, and correspondence-related work on behalf of an individual, department, or organization**, ensuring smooth communication and organization of information. The role ranges from routine clerical support (a personal/private secretary) to a senior statutory position with significant legal and governance responsibilities (a company secretary — covered further in Unit IV).

Importance of a Secretary

- **Supports efficient administration** — Handles routine administrative tasks, freeing up executives/management to focus on strategic decision-making
 - **Acts as a communication link** — Serves as an important channel of communication between the executive/organization and external parties (clients, visitors, other departments)
 - **Maintains confidentiality** — Often privy to sensitive/confidential information, playing a trusted role in protecting organizational interests
 - **Ensures organizational efficiency** — Through effective scheduling, correspondence handling, and record-keeping, a good secretary significantly improves overall office efficiency
 - **Represents the organization's image** — As often the first point of contact for visitors and callers, a secretary's professionalism reflects directly on the organization's public image
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2. Kinds of Secretaries

- **Private/Personal Secretary** — Works directly for and assists one individual (typically a senior executive), handling that person's

correspondence, scheduling, and administrative tasks

- **Departmental Secretary** — Provides secretarial support to an entire department rather than a single individual
- **Company Secretary** — A senior statutory position (in many jurisdictions, a mandatory legal appointment for certain companies) responsible for ensuring the company complies with legal and regulatory requirements, and for managing key governance functions such as board meetings (explored in depth in Unit IV)
- **Legal Secretary** — Specializes in providing secretarial support within a legal context (law firms, legal departments), often requiring specific knowledge of legal terminology and documentation
- **Freelance/Virtual Secretary** — Provides secretarial support remotely, often to multiple clients, rather than being employed full-time by a single organization (connecting to the virtual office concept from Unit I)

Exam tip: “Kinds of secretaries” is a common 2-mark/6-mark question — be ready to name and briefly distinguish at least the Private Secretary, Company Secretary, and Departmental Secretary, since these are the most fundamental distinctions.

3. Qualifications and Qualities of a Secretary

Qualifications

- Relevant educational qualification (commerce/business administration background is common; a Company Secretary role typically requires specific professional certification, as covered in Unit IV)
- Proficiency in office skills — typing, shorthand (traditionally), and increasingly, proficiency with digital office tools (word processing, spreadsheets, email, presentation software)
- Knowledge of business correspondence formats and office procedures
- For specialized roles (company secretary, legal secretary) — specific professional or legal knowledge relevant to that context

Qualities

- **Communication skills** — Both written and verbal, since much of the role involves drafting correspondence and interacting with visitors/callers
- **Organizational ability** — Managing schedules, correspondence, and records efficiently requires strong organizational skills

- **Discretion and confidentiality** — Given access to sensitive information, trustworthiness and discretion are essential qualities
- **Attention to detail** — Accuracy in correspondence, scheduling, and record-keeping is critical, since errors can have significant consequences
- **Interpersonal skills** — Since secretaries frequently interact with visitors, callers, and staff at all levels, strong interpersonal skills help maintain positive relationships
- **Initiative and adaptability** — The ability to anticipate needs, solve routine problems independently, and adapt to changing priorities

Exam tip: “Qualities of a good secretary” is a frequently tested 6-mark question — aim for at least 5-6 distinct qualities from the list above.

4. Duties and Responsibilities of a Secretary

- **Correspondence Management** — Drafting, typing, and managing incoming/outgoing correspondence on behalf of the employer/organization
- **Appointment and Diary Management** — Scheduling and managing appointments, meetings, and the employer’s calendar
- **Reception and Visitor Handling** — Receiving visitors, screening calls, and managing access to the executive/office (explored further below)
- **Record-Keeping and Filing** — Maintaining organized records and files, applying the filing principles covered in Unit I
- **Meeting Support** — Assisting with meeting arrangements, preparing agendas, and taking minutes where required (this role expands significantly at the Company Secretary level, covered in Unit IV)
- **Confidential Task Handling** — Managing sensitive or confidential matters on behalf of the employer with discretion
- **Coordination** — Acting as a liaison between the employer/department and other parts of the organization or external stakeholders

Part B: Business Communication

5. Drafting of Business Letters

Business letters are formal written communications used for official correspondence between organizations, or between an organization and individuals (clients, suppliers, employees).

Key Principles of Good Business Letter Drafting (the “7 Cs of Communication” — commonly tested)

- **Clarity** — The message should be clear and easily understood, avoiding ambiguity
- **Conciseness** — The letter should convey the message using as few words as necessary, without unnecessary padding
- **Correctness** — Information, grammar, and facts presented must be accurate
- **Completeness** — All necessary information should be included so the reader doesn’t need to seek clarification
- **Courtesy** — The tone should be polite and respectful, even when delivering difficult messages
- **Consideration** — The letter should be written keeping the reader’s perspective and needs in mind
- **Concreteness** — The message should be specific and definite, rather than vague or abstract

Common Types of Business Letters

- Inquiry letters, quotation letters, order letters, complaint letters, and follow-up/collection letters, among others — each following a generally standard business letter format (date, address, salutation, subject, body, closing, signature)

Exam tip: The “7 Cs of Communication” is one of the most predictable topics in this section — a 6-mark question may directly ask “Explain the essentials/principles of effective business correspondence,” so make sure you can list and briefly explain all seven.

6. Notices, Agenda, Office Memoranda, Circulars & Email Communication

Notice

A Notice is a **formal written announcement informing relevant parties (employees, members, shareholders) about an upcoming event, meeting, or important information**. A notice for a meeting typically specifies the date, time, venue, and purpose of the meeting (this becomes particularly important for company meetings, covered in depth in Unit IV).

Agenda

An Agenda is a **list of items/topics to be discussed at a meeting**, prepared and circulated in advance to give participants time to prepare. A well-prepared agenda ensures the meeting stays focused and covers all necessary topics within the available time (this is explored in greater depth alongside meeting management in Unit IV).

Office Memorandum (Memo)

A Memorandum is a **brief, informal written communication used for internal communication within an organization**, typically used to convey instructions, information, or reminders between departments or staff members. Memos are usually shorter and less formal than full business letters, often following a simplified format (To, From, Date, Subject, Message).

Circular

A Circular is a **written communication sent simultaneously to multiple recipients**, typically used to convey information, instructions, or policy changes that are relevant to a group of people at once (e.g., a circular announcing a change in office timings, sent to all employees).

Email Communication

Email has become the dominant medium for both internal and external business communication in the modern office, offering speed, convenience, and an easily searchable/archivable record of communication. Good email communication practice includes:

- Using clear, specific subject lines
- Maintaining a professional tone, similar to formal business letters
- Being concise while including all necessary information (applying the 7 Cs discussed above)
- Using appropriate greetings and sign-offs
- Being mindful of recipients (To vs. Cc vs. Bcc) and confidentiality

Exam tip: “Differentiate between a memo and a circular” or “memo vs. letter” are common 2-mark comparisons — the key distinguishing points are: memo = internal + informal + usually one-to-one or small group; circular = sent simultaneously to multiple/all recipients; letter = more formal, often external.

7. Reception and Handling of Visitors

Effective visitor management is an important secretarial function that directly shapes the organization's professional image.

Key aspects of visitor handling:

- **Greeting and welcoming** — Visitors should be greeted promptly and courteously upon arrival
 - **Screening and verification** — Confirming the visitor's identity and purpose of visit before granting access to the relevant person/department
 - **Appointment verification** — Checking whether the visitor has a scheduled appointment, and handling walk-in visitors appropriately
 - **Guiding/directing visitors** — Ensuring visitors are comfortably seated and informed about expected waiting times, or guided to the correct location
 - **Maintaining a visitor register** — Recording visitor details (name, purpose, time in/out) for security and record-keeping purposes
 - **Handling difficult situations tactfully** — Managing situations such as unscheduled visitors, unhappy clients, or security concerns with tact and professionalism
-

8. Telephone Etiquette

Telephone etiquette refers to the **professional standards and practices expected when handling telephone calls** on behalf of an organization.

Key principles of good telephone etiquette:

- **Prompt answering** — Calls should be answered quickly, typically within a few rings
- **Professional greeting** — Answering with a clear, professional greeting that identifies the organization/department
- **Active listening** — Paying full attention to the caller's query without interrupting
- **Clear and polite speech** — Speaking clearly, at an appropriate pace, and maintaining a courteous tone throughout the call
- **Accurate message-taking** — When taking messages on behalf of someone else, accurately recording caller name, contact details, time of call, and the message itself
- **Appropriate call transferring/holding** — Informing callers before placing them on hold or transferring their call, and doing so smoothly
- **Confidentiality** — Avoiding disclosure of sensitive/confidential

information over the phone to unverified callers

9. Appointment Scheduling

Appointment scheduling involves **managing an executive's or department's calendar to arrange meetings and commitments efficiently**, avoiding conflicts and ensuring adequate time is allocated for each engagement.

Key aspects:

- Maintaining an accurate, up-to-date diary/calendar (increasingly managed through digital calendar tools)
 - Confirming appointments with all relevant parties in advance
 - Allowing adequate buffer time between appointments
 - Prioritizing urgent or important appointments appropriately
 - Sending timely reminders to reduce missed appointments
 - Handling rescheduling or cancellations professionally and promptly communicating changes to affected parties
-

10. Mail Handling: Inward and Outward Correspondence

Inward (Incoming) Mail Handling

The systematic process of receiving, sorting, recording, and distributing mail/correspondence that arrives at the organization. Typical steps include:

1. Receiving and opening mail (except items marked confidential/personal, which are forwarded unopened)
2. Sorting mail by department/recipient and urgency
3. Recording/logging mail received (often in an inward mail register, noting sender, date, and reference number)
4. Distributing mail promptly to the relevant department/individual
5. Following up to ensure timely action/response where needed

Outward (Outgoing) Mail Handling

The systematic process of preparing, recording, and dispatching correspondence sent out by the organization. Typical steps include:

1. Ensuring outgoing correspondence is properly drafted, checked, and authorized/signed
2. Recording outgoing mail (in an outward mail register, noting recipient, date, and reference)

3. Proper packaging/addressing to ensure correct and secure delivery
4. Selecting the appropriate dispatch method (post, courier, email) based on urgency and nature of the correspondence
5. Maintaining copies/records of all outgoing correspondence for future reference

Exam tip: “Explain the procedure for handling inward and outward mail” is a common 6-mark question — presenting your answer as two clear step-by-step sequences (Inward steps, then Outward steps) mirrors how examiners expect this answer to be structured.

11. Office Communication Systems

Beyond individual correspondence, offices rely on broader communication systems and channels to ensure smooth information flow:

- **Formal Communication Channels** — Official, structured channels following the organization’s hierarchy (e.g., memos, official reports, circulars)
- **Informal Communication Channels** — Unofficial, personal communication between employees (sometimes called the “grapevine”), which can be fast but less reliable/accurate
- **Vertical Communication** — Flowing up and down the organizational hierarchy (management to staff, and staff to management)
- **Horizontal Communication** — Flowing between employees/departments at the same organizational level, supporting coordination
- **Modern Communication Tools** — Email, instant messaging platforms, video conferencing, and intranet systems, which have increasingly supplemented (and in some cases replaced) traditional paper-based communication, connecting back to the paperless/virtual office concepts from Unit I

Exam tip: “Types of communication channels in an office” (formal vs. informal, vertical vs. horizontal) is a solid 6-mark question — make sure you can define each type clearly and give one example.

Quick Revision Summary

TOPIC	ONE-LINE TAKEAWAY
Secretary meaning	Handles administrative, clerical, and

	correspondence work for an individual/organization
Kinds of secretaries	Private, Departmental, Company, Legal, Freelance/Virtual Secretary
Qualifications	Relevant education, office skills (typing, digital tools), correspondence knowledge
Qualities	Communication skills, organization, discretion, attention to detail, interpersonal skills
Duties	Correspondence, appointments, reception, filing, meeting support, confidentiality
7 Cs of Communication	Clarity, Conciseness, Correctness, Completeness, Courtesy, Consideration, Concreteness
Notice	Formal announcement of an event/meeting
Agenda	List of topics to be discussed at a meeting
Memo	Brief, informal internal communication
Circular	Communication sent simultaneously to multiple recipients
Visitor handling	Greeting, screening, verifying appointments, maintaining visitor register
Telephone etiquette	Prompt, professional, clear, polite, accurate message-taking, confidentiality
Appointment scheduling	Managing calendar to avoid conflicts and ensure smooth engagements
Inward mail handling	Receive → sort → record → distribute → follow up
Outward mail handling	Draft/authorize → record → package → dispatch → retain copy
Communication channels	Formal vs informal; vertical vs horizontal

Unit IV: Company Office Procedures and Meeting Management

(BBA Sem 3 — VOC169 — 7 Lectures)

Part A: Company Secretary and Company Officers

1. Secretary — Appointment, Qualifications, Functions and Position

The Company Secretary

Building on the general concept of a “secretary” introduced in Unit III, a **Company Secretary** is a **senior officer of a company responsible for ensuring the company complies with statutory and regulatory requirements, and for managing key corporate governance functions**, particularly relating to board and shareholder meetings. Unlike a private/personal secretary (an informal, non-statutory role), a Company Secretary holds a formally recognized position under company law in many jurisdictions.

Appointment

- A Company Secretary is typically **appointed by the Board of Directors** of the company
- In many jurisdictions, companies above a certain size/turnover threshold are **legally required** to appoint a qualified Company Secretary (i.e., it is a mandatory statutory position, not merely optional)
- The appointment, terms, and remuneration are usually formalized through a board resolution

Qualifications

- A Company Secretary typically must hold a **recognized professional qualification** (e.g., membership of the relevant professional Institute of Company Secretaries in the given jurisdiction)
- Sound knowledge of company law, corporate governance principles, and secretarial practice

- Strong understanding of compliance and regulatory requirements applicable to the company's industry

Functions of a Company Secretary

- **Ensuring statutory compliance** — Ensuring the company complies with company law and other applicable regulations (e.g., timely filing of statutory returns and documents with regulatory authorities)
- **Managing board and shareholder meetings** — Organizing meetings, preparing notices and agendas, and recording minutes (explored in depth later in this unit)
- **Maintaining statutory registers and records** — Keeping the company's official records (register of members, register of directors, minute books) accurately updated
- **Advising the Board** — Providing guidance to directors on legal, regulatory, and governance matters
- **Liaising with regulatory authorities** — Acting as the company's official point of contact for regulatory bodies and ensuring timely regulatory filings
- **Custodian of the company seal** (where applicable) — Historically responsible for the safekeeping and proper use of the company's official seal on important documents

Position in the Office and Company Setup

The Company Secretary typically holds a senior management-level position, often reporting directly to the Board of Directors or the Chairman, and works closely with the company's top management. The role sits at the intersection of administration, legal compliance, and corporate governance — distinguishing it clearly from the more general clerical/administrative secretarial roles discussed in Unit III.

Exam tip: "Appointment, qualifications and functions of a Company Secretary" is a very high-probability 6-mark question — structure your answer using these four clear sub-headings (Appointment, Qualifications, Functions, Position), since this mirrors how the topic is typically examined.

2. Basic Knowledge of Directors, Chairman and Auditor

Directors

Directors are individuals **elected/appointed by the shareholders to manage the overall affairs of the company** on their behalf, collectively forming the Board of Directors.

- **Roles and Responsibilities:** Setting company strategy and policy, overseeing management performance, ensuring the company operates within legal and ethical boundaries (connecting to the governance principles from your Business Environment, Ethics & Governance subject), and safeguarding shareholder interests
- Directors owe a **fiduciary duty** to the company — meaning they must act in good faith and in the best interests of the company and its shareholders, rather than for personal gain

Chairman

The Chairman is the **head of the Board of Directors**, responsible for leading and presiding over board meetings.

- **Roles and Responsibilities:** Presiding over and conducting board and general meetings in an orderly manner, ensuring all directors/shareholders have a fair opportunity to express views, casting a deciding/casting vote in case of a tie (where permitted by the company's rules), and representing the company in a ceremonial/leadership capacity

Auditor

An Auditor is an **independent professional appointed to examine and verify the accuracy and fairness of a company's financial statements and records**, ensuring they present a true and fair view of the company's financial position.

- **Roles and Responsibilities:** Conducting an independent audit of the company's accounts, reporting to shareholders on whether the financial statements are accurate and comply with applicable accounting standards, and flagging any irregularities or concerns identified during the audit process
- The auditor's independence from company management is a critical safeguard for shareholders and other stakeholders relying on the accuracy of financial statements

Exam tip: "Roles and responsibilities of directors, chairman, and auditor" is a common 6-mark question — keep each role's explanation focused and distinct: Directors = overall management/strategy; Chairman = leads the Board/meetings; Auditor = independent financial verification.

Part B: Meeting Management

3. Meaning and Types of Meetings

Meaning

A Meeting is a **formal or informal gathering of two or more people convened for a specific purpose**, such as discussing issues, making decisions, or sharing information. In a company/business context, meetings are often governed by specific legal and procedural requirements, particularly for statutory company meetings.

Types of Meetings (Company Context)

- **Board Meetings** — Meetings of the Board of Directors, held to discuss and decide on matters relating to the company's management and strategy; companies are typically required to hold board meetings at a minimum prescribed frequency
- **Annual General Meeting (AGM)** — A mandatory yearly meeting of the company's shareholders, at which key matters such as approval of financial statements, declaration of dividends, and appointment/reappointment of directors and auditors are typically addressed
- **Extraordinary General Meeting (EGM)** — A meeting of shareholders called to address urgent or special matters that cannot wait until the next AGM (e.g., approval of a major transaction, urgent changes to company structure)
- **Statutory Meeting** — In some jurisdictions, a special meeting of shareholders required to be held within a specified period after a company's incorporation, to inform shareholders about the company's formation and initial position
- **Committee Meetings** — Meetings of specific committees formed by the Board (e.g., audit committee, remuneration committee) to address specialized areas of governance

Exam tip: "Types of company meetings" is a very frequently tested 6-mark question — make sure you can clearly distinguish AGM (mandatory annual, all shareholders) from EGM (special/urgent matters, called as needed) and from Board Meetings (directors only, not shareholders).

4. Duties of the Secretary Before, During and After Meetings

Before the Meeting

- Preparing and circulating the **notice** of the meeting (specifying date, time, venue, and purpose) to all eligible participants within the legally/procedurally required notice period
- Preparing and circulating the **agenda** (the list of items to be

discussed)

- Arranging the **venue**, necessary documents, and any equipment/technology required for the meeting
- Confirming quorum requirements are likely to be met (ensuring enough participants are expected to attend, since a meeting cannot validly proceed without quorum — explained below)
- Compiling and distributing relevant background documents/reports needed for informed discussion at the meeting

During the Meeting

- Recording attendance of participants
- Verifying and confirming **quorum** is present before proceeding
- Taking detailed, accurate notes of discussions, decisions, and resolutions passed, to prepare the minutes afterward
- Assisting the Chairman in ensuring the meeting proceeds smoothly and in an orderly manner, following the agenda
- Recording the results of any **voting** conducted on resolutions/motions

After the Meeting

- Preparing and finalizing the **minutes** of the meeting (explored in detail below)
- Circulating the minutes to relevant participants for record and, where required, for approval at the next meeting
- Following up on **action items** assigned during the meeting to ensure they are executed
- Filing/recording the minutes appropriately in the company's official minute book, and ensuring statutory filing requirements (if any) related to the meeting's outcomes are completed

Exam tip: “Duties of a secretary before, during, and after a meeting” is one of the most predictable and important 6-mark questions in this entire subject — structure your answer using exactly these three time-based sub-headings, since this is precisely how the question is typically framed.

5. Notice, Agenda, Quorum, Voting, Motions and Resolutions

Notice

As introduced in Unit III, in the specific context of company meetings, a Notice must typically specify the date, time, venue, and purpose of the meeting, and must be circulated within a

legally/procedurally prescribed minimum notice period to all persons entitled to attend.

Agenda

The Agenda for a company meeting lists, in order, all the items/matters to be discussed and decided upon. A well-prepared agenda typically includes routine items (e.g., approval of previous minutes) as well as specific matters requiring discussion or decision at that particular meeting.

Quorum

Quorum refers to the **minimum number of members/directors required to be present at a meeting for the proceedings to be considered valid**. If a quorum is not present, the meeting generally cannot legally proceed to transact business, and may need to be adjourned/rescheduled. Quorum requirements are typically specified in the company's constitutional documents (articles of association) or under applicable company law.

Voting

Voting refers to the **formal process by which members/directors express their approval or disapproval of a proposed motion/resolution**. Common methods of voting in company meetings include:

- **Voting by show of hands** — A simple method where each member present has one vote, regardless of shareholding, typically used for straightforward, non-contentious matters
- **Voting by poll** — A more formal method where votes are typically weighted according to shareholding (e.g., one vote per share), used for more significant matters or when specifically demanded

Motions and Resolutions

- A **Motion** is a **formal proposal put forward for discussion and decision at a meeting**. Once a motion is discussed and voted upon and passed, it becomes a resolution.
- A **Resolution** is the **formal decision/outcome reached by the members through voting on a motion**. Resolutions are typically classified based on the level of approval required:
 - **Ordinary Resolution** — Requires a simple majority of votes to pass (used for routine business matters)
 - **Special Resolution** — Requires a higher threshold of approval (e.g., a supermajority, such as 75% or three-fourths of votes cast) to pass, typically required for more significant decisions affecting the company's structure or shareholder

rights (e.g., changes to the company's constitutional documents)

Exam tip: “Explain quorum, motion, and resolution” and “Ordinary vs Special resolution” are both frequently tested — make sure you know that the key distinguishing point between ordinary and special resolutions is the **voting threshold required** (simple majority vs. supermajority).

6. Minutes Writing

Meaning of Minutes

Minutes are the **official, formal written record of the proceedings, discussions, decisions, and resolutions passed at a meeting**. They serve as the authoritative, legally significant record of what transpired and what was decided.

Importance of Minutes

- Serve as **legal evidence** of decisions taken and matters discussed at the meeting
- Provide a **reference point** for follow-up on action items and implementation of decisions
- Ensure **accountability**, since minutes create a documented record of who was present and what was collectively decided
- Support **continuity**, allowing those who could not attend (or future readers) to understand what transpired

Types of Minutes

- **Minutes of Narration** — A more detailed record that includes not just the final decisions but also a summary of the discussion, arguments, and viewpoints expressed by participants leading up to the decision
- **Minutes of Resolution** — A more concise record that states only the final resolutions/decisions passed, without detailing the discussion that led to them — this is the more common and generally preferred format for formal company meeting minutes, since it is more concise and avoids potential disputes over how discussions are characterized

Minutes Book

The Minutes Book is the **official register/book in which the minutes of all meetings (Board meetings, AGMs, EGMs) are permanently recorded and maintained**, in accordance with

statutory requirements. It is typically maintained by the Company Secretary and serves as a permanent, authoritative record that may need to be produced for regulatory inspection or legal purposes.

Contents of Minutes

A well-prepared set of minutes typically includes:

- Type of meeting, company name, date, time, and venue
- List of attendees present (and, where relevant, those who sent apologies for absence)
- Confirmation that quorum was present
- Confirmation/approval of minutes of the previous meeting
- A record of each agenda item discussed, along with the resolution/decision reached on each
- Details of voting outcomes, where relevant
- Time of closure of the meeting
- Signature of the Chairman (or other authorized person), authenticating the minutes as an accurate record

Exam tip: “Contents of minutes” and “types of minutes” are both common 6-mark questions — for contents, aim to list at least 6-7 elements from the list above; for types, make sure you can clearly distinguish Minutes of Narration (detailed, includes discussion) from Minutes of Resolution (concise, decisions only).

Quick Revision Summary

TOPIC	ONE-LINE TAKEAWAY
Company Secretary	Senior statutory officer ensuring legal compliance and managing governance/meetings
CS appointment	Appointed by the Board of Directors; mandatory for companies above a certain size
CS functions	Statutory compliance, managing meetings, maintaining records, advising the Board
Directors	Elected by shareholders to manage company affairs; owe fiduciary duty
Chairman	Heads the Board; presides over and conducts meetings
Auditor	Independent professional verifying accuracy of financial statements

Types of meetings	Board Meeting, AGM (mandatory annual), EGM (special/urgent), Statutory Meeting, Committee Meeting
Secretary's duties before meeting	Notice, agenda, venue arrangement, quorum check, document circulation
Secretary's duties during meeting	Attendance, quorum verification, note-taking, recording voting
Secretary's duties after meeting	Prepare/circulate minutes, follow up on action items, file records
Quorum	Minimum members required for a valid meeting
Voting methods	Show of hands (one member, one vote) vs. Poll (weighted by shareholding)
Motion vs Resolution	Motion = proposal; Resolution = formal decision after voting
Ordinary vs Special Resolution	Ordinary = simple majority; Special = supermajority (e.g., 75%)
Minutes	Official written record of meeting proceedings and decisions
Types of minutes	Minutes of Narration (detailed) vs. Minutes of Resolution (concise, decisions only)
Minutes Book	Official permanent register recording all meeting minutes